# Still Lit

A Gentle Guide for Single Women Who Feel Alone at Christmas: Quiet the Loneliness, Face the Family Questions and Create a Season That Finally Feels Like Home

Clara Whitfield

Copyright © 2026 Clara Whitfield. All rights reserved.

This book is for general information and encouragement only. It is not medical, psychological, legal or financial advice and is not a substitute for help from a qualified professional. If you are in crisis or thinking about harming yourself, contact your local emergency number or a crisis line right away (in the US, call or text 988; in the UK, call Samaritans at 116 123).

Written with the help of AI tools and carefully edited. Illustrations created with the help of AI.

# A Letter Before We Begin

*It's the second week of December. The lights are up on every street. Your phone buzzes with a photo of someone else's perfect table, and a voice inside you whispers the thing you'd never say out loud: "Everyone has someone. Except me."*

*If you know that voice, this book was written for you.*

The candle in the window on this book's cover is still lit. So are you. Whatever this season has taken from you (a person, a marriage, a tradition, a picture of how life was supposed to look), it has not taken your warmth. This book will help you find it again, one evening at a time.

If you picked up this book, there is a good chance that the holidays feel a little heavy right now. Maybe you are newly single. Maybe you have been single for years and usually love it, until December arrives with its couples in matching sweaters, its family group chats, and its endless question: *"So, what are your plans?"* Maybe someone you love is gone, or far away, or simply not the person you hoped they would be. Maybe you are not sad at all, just tired of feeling like the season was designed for someone else.

Whatever brought you here, I want you to know one thing before anything else: **there is nothing wrong with you.** The holidays are loud. They come with a script, and most of us were never asked whether we wanted the part we were given. Feeling lonely, irritated, nostalgic, relieved, or all of those within one afternoon is not a failure. It is a normal human response to a season that turns the volume up on everything.

This book will not ask you to pretend. It will not tell you to "just be grateful" or to "put yourself out there" before you are ready. Instead, it will help you do three practical things:

1. **Understand what you are feeling**, so the feelings stop running the show.
2. **Plan the season on purpose**, day by day, so the hardest days do not catch you unprepared.
3. **Build a holiday that actually feels like yours**, with small rituals, real connection and a lot less pressure.

Each chapter ends with a short practice: a question to journal, a script to borrow, or a worksheet to fill in. You do not have to do them all. Pick what helps. Skip what doesn't. Come back to a page on a hard evening. This is a companion, not homework.

A gentle note: this book is meant for the ordinary heaviness that many women feel during the holidays. If what you are carrying feels bigger than that, if you are struggling to get through the day, or if you have thoughts of harming yourself, please read the chapter "When It's More Than the Holiday Blues" first and reach out to a professional or a crisis line today. You deserve real support, not just a book.

Now, make yourself something warm to drink. Let's begin.

# Chapter 1: Name What You Feel



The first step is the simplest and, oddly, the one most of us skip. We go straight from *"I feel bad"* to *"What is wrong with me?"* without ever stopping to ask *"What exactly am I feeling?"*

Feelings that are named become smaller. Feelings that stay vague grow in the dark.

## The holiday feelings nobody mentions

Here are some of the emotions women describe when they spend the holidays single, separated, widowed, or simply without the picture-perfect setup. See which ones sound familiar:

- **Loneliness**: the ache of wanting someone to share the moments with.
- **Grief**: for a person, a marriage, a family tradition, or a version of life you expected to have by now.
- **Comparison**: the sting of scrolling past engagement photos and family pajamas.
- **Shame**: the sense that being alone says something bad about you. (It does not.)
- **Anger**: at an ex, at family members, at the endless questions.
- **Relief**: yes, relief. Many women feel lighter without a difficult partner or a tense family gathering, and then feel guilty about the relief.
- **Pressure**: to make the season magical for children, parents or friends, even when you are running on empty.
- **Nostalgia**: for holidays that may never have been as perfect as memory paints them.

You might feel several of these at once. That is not confusion. That is being human in December.

## Why the holidays amplify everything

Three things make this season emotionally louder than the rest of the year:

**1. The script.** Movies, ads and social media all tell the same story: a cozy home, a partner, laughing children, a big family table. When your life does not match the script, your brain registers it as a gap, even if your life is good.

**2. The calendar.** Holidays are anniversaries. They hold memories of every year before, which means they hold every loss too.

**3. The pause.** Work slows down. Routines disappear. The things that normally keep us busy and connected (colleagues, gym classes, school runs) take a break, and the quiet can feel very loud.

Understanding this does not make the feelings disappear. But it helps you stop taking them as evidence that your life is going wrong. They are a predictable reaction to a predictable season.

## The "and" practice

One of the most freeing tools for this season is a tiny word: *and.* Instead of choosing between "I am fine" and "I am falling apart," try holding both:

> *I miss the way Christmas used to be, and I am proud of the life I am building.*

> *I feel lonely tonight, and I know this feeling will pass.*

> *I am relieved I am not with him this year, and I am sad that it ended.*

You are allowed to feel more than one thing. The "and" makes room for all of you.

## Practice: Your feelings check-in

Take five minutes. Write down what you are feeling right now, as specifically as you can. Use the list above if it helps. Then finish the sentence: *"Underneath this feeling, what I really need is…"*

Most feelings point to a need: rest, connection, reassurance, a change of scene, a good cry. Once you know the need, you can start meeting it. That is what the rest of this book is about.

# Chapter 2: Step Out of the Comparison Trap

There is a particular kind of loneliness that only arrives through a screen. You are fine, genuinely fine, until you see a friend's photo of a candlelit dinner for two, or a cousin's family of five in matching reindeer sweaters. Suddenly your quiet evening feels like proof that you are missing out.

## What you are actually comparing

When you compare your life to someone else's holiday photo, you are comparing your whole, unfiltered reality, including the dishes in the sink and the thoughts at 2 a.m., to one carefully chosen second of theirs. You do not see the argument in the car on the way there. You do not see the partner who scrolled their phone through dinner, or the mother who cried in the bathroom because the turkey burned.

This is not to say that other people are secretly miserable. Many of them are happy, and that is lovely. The point is simply this: **a photo is not a life.** It is a moment, edited and shared. Your life deserves to be judged by how it feels from the inside, not by how it would look on someone else's feed.

## A gentle digital plan for December

You do not need to delete every app. But you might want to decide, ahead of time, how and when you will use them. Here are a few ideas women have found helpful:

- **Mute, don't unfollow.** Most platforms let you quietly mute accounts for 30 days. Nobody is notified. Use it generously.
- **Set "no-scroll windows."** For example, no social media after 9 p.m., or not on Christmas Eve and Christmas Day.
- **Move the apps.** Put social apps in a folder on the last screen of your phone. A few extra taps are often enough to break the habit.
- **Replace, don't just remove.** When you reach for your phone, have something else ready: an audiobook, a crossword, a podcast, a friend to text directly.
- **Post for yourself, if you post at all.** If you share your holiday, share what you enjoyed, not what you think will impress.

## Your own highlight reel

Here is a small, surprisingly powerful exercise. For the next seven days, write down one good moment from each day. Not big moments. Small ones: the first sip of coffee, a funny message from a friend, the smell of oranges, finishing a chapter of a book, a stranger holding a door.

By the end of the week, you will have your own highlight reel, and it will be real.

**My good moments this week**

## Practice: The comparison question

The next time you feel the sting of comparison, ask yourself: *"What is this photo showing me that I want?"* Sometimes the answer is "a partner." But often it is something smaller and more reachable: warmth, company, a reason to dress up, a beautiful table, a tradition. Write down three things you noticed you wanted this week, and one small way you could give yourself a version of each.

# Chapter 3: Family Gatherings and "The Question"

For many single women, the hardest part of the holidays is not being alone. It is being *with* people who keep pointing out that you are alone.

*"So, are you seeing anyone?"*

*"Don't wait too long, you know."*

*"Your sister is so happy with her family."*

*"What happened with that nice man?"*

Most of these comments are not meant to hurt. Relatives often ask because they do not know what else to talk about, or because they genuinely want you to be happy and assume happiness means a partner. But intention does not cancel impact. A dinner full of these questions can leave you drained for days.

## Decide before you arrive

The best time to handle a difficult conversation is before it happens. Before any gathering, take ten minutes and decide three things:

1. **How long you will stay.** "I'll be there from 2 until 6." Having an end time makes the hard parts easier to bear.
2. **How you will get away if you need to.** Drive yourself. Know where the quiet room is. Plan a walk with the dog or a "quick trip to the store."

3. **What you will say.** Choose your answers ahead of time, so you are not caught off guard.

## Scripts you can borrow

You do not owe anyone a detailed explanation of your love life, your divorce, or your plans. Here are some answers, from light to firm, that you can use word for word:

**Light and friendly**

- "Not at the moment, and honestly I'm enjoying the peace. How's your garden doing?"
- "Nobody special yet. But I did take up pottery this year, want to see what I made?"

**Warm but clear**

- "I know you ask because you care. I'm happy with where I am right now."
- "I'd rather not talk about dating today, but I'd love to hear about your trip."

**Firm**

- "That's not something I'm going to discuss today."
- "I've answered that already. Let's talk about something else."

Notice that most of these scripts end with a change of subject. People rarely push past a friendly redirect. If someone does, it is perfectly acceptable to excuse yourself and step outside for a few minutes.

## When the gathering itself is hard

Sometimes the problem is not one question. It is the whole setting: the family member you do not get along with, the ex's relatives at a shared event, the noise, the alcohol, the old roles you slip into the moment you walk through the door.

A few things that help:

- **Bring a job.** Offer to bring a dish, set the table, or run games for the kids. Having a role gives you something to do with your hands and somewhere to put your attention.
- **Find your ally.** Is there one cousin, aunt or friend who gets it? Sit near them. Agree on a signal for "rescue me."
- **Step outside once an hour.** Even five minutes of fresh air resets your nervous system.
- **Go easy on alcohol.** It lowers your guard and raises the chance of saying something you will regret, or feeling worse later.
- **Leave on time, without apology.** "Thank you so much, this was lovely. I'm heading off now." That's all.

## Skipping a gathering is allowed

If a family event consistently leaves you hurt, you are allowed to change how you take part. You can visit for one hour instead of a whole day. You can host your own smaller event. You can see your family on a different date, when the pressure is lower. You can skip it altogether this year.

None of these choices make you a bad daughter, sister or aunt. They make you someone who is taking care of herself so she can show up well in other ways.

## Practice: Your gathering plan

**Event:**

**I'll arrive at / leave by:**

**My exit plan if I need a break:**

**My go-to answer for "The Question":**

**My ally at this event:**

**Something I'll do afterwards to recharge:**

# Chapter 4: Plan Your Season on Purpose

One of the biggest reasons the holidays feel overwhelming when you are single is that they arrive without a plan. Couples and families often have their schedules decided for them: whose parents on which day, which party, which traditions. When you are on your own, the days can stretch out empty, and empty days have a way of filling up with worry.

The solution is not to cram every day full. It is to look at the season ahead and decide, gently and on purpose, how you want it to feel.

## Step 1: Choose three words

Before you plan anything, ask yourself: *"How do I want to feel this December?"* Choose three words. Some examples women have chosen:

- *Calm, cozy, connected*
- *Free, playful, rested*
- *Brave, kind, open*
- *Quiet, healing, hopeful*

Write your words somewhere you will see them: on your phone's lock screen, on a sticky note on the mirror. Every time you decide whether to say yes to an invitation, a purchase or a plan, ask: *"Does this help me feel my three words?"*

**My three words for this season:**

## Step 2: Map the "pressure points"

Look at the calendar from now until the first week of January. Mark the days that are most likely to feel hard. For many women, these include:

- The office party or a friend's couples' dinner
- The first weekend of December, when everyone starts decorating
- Christmas Eve and Christmas Day
- The quiet days between Christmas and New Year
- New Year's Eve
- Any personal anniversaries: a wedding date, a loss, a birthday

Those are your pressure points. You will give each one a plan.

## Step 3: Give every hard day an anchor

An anchor is one thing planned for a day that might otherwise feel empty or heavy. It does not need to be big. It needs to be *something to look forward to*. Ideas:

- A morning walk with a friend, or a phone call scheduled in advance
- A film marathon with a special snack you bought just for it
- Volunteering for a few hours
- A cooking project: a new recipe, a big pot of soup to share
- A spa day at home, or a swim at a local pool
- A day trip somewhere you have never been

- A long bath, a new book and an early night

## Step 4: Protect your energy

For every two social plans, schedule one quiet recovery block. This is especially important if you are an introvert, if family events are draining, or if you are grieving. Rest is not wasted time. It is what makes the good moments possible.

## Practice: Your holiday map

**Hard day: _____ Anchor: _____**

**Hard day: _____ Anchor: _____**

**Hard day: _____ Anchor: _____**

**Hard day: _____ Anchor: _____**

**Quiet recovery blocks I'll protect:**

# Chapter 5: Rituals for One

Traditions are one of the hardest things to lose. The ornament you always hung together. The Christmas morning pancakes. The family walk after lunch. When a relationship ends or a family changes, the traditions often go with it, and the empty spaces they leave can hurt more than the big absences.

But here is a hopeful truth: **traditions are invented.** Every tradition you have ever loved was once done for the first time. You can start new ones, today, that belong only to you.

## What makes a ritual feel meaningful

A ritual is more than an activity. It has three ingredients:

1. **Intention.** You do it on purpose, not by accident.
2. **Repetition.** You do it again, next week or next year.
3. **Sensory detail.** A particular song, scent, food, candle or place that makes it feel special.

A cup of tea is a drink. A cup of your favorite spiced tea, in the same mug, by the window, every evening in December while you write one good thing that happened that day: that is a ritual.

## Ideas for solo holiday rituals

Choose one or two that make you smile. Change them as you like.

- **The ornament of the year.** Buy or make one ornament each year that represents something you did or learned. Over time, your tree tells your story.

- **A December book.** Pick one special book to read only in December, a little each evening.
- **Light a candle for what you're letting go.** On the winter solstice, write down one thing you are ready to release, and one thing you are ready to welcome.
- **A solo "date" each week.** Ice skating, a concert, a market, a fancy hot chocolate: put on something nice and take yourself out.
- **Christmas morning breakfast.** Make something you would never make on an ordinary day: cinnamon rolls, eggs Benedict, a full pancake stack.
- **The gratitude jar.** Each day, write one small good thing on a slip of paper. Read them all on New Year's Day.
- **A walk at first light.** Many towns are beautiful and quiet early on Christmas morning.
- **Letters to your future self.** Write to the woman you'll be next December. Seal it. Open it next year.

## If you have children

Many single mothers spend part of the holidays without their children because of custody arrangements. If that is you, those days can be some of the hardest of the year. A few ideas:

- **Celebrate on a different day.** Children don't mind when "your Christmas" happens. A December 27th celebration with stockings and pancakes can be just as magical.
- **Create a "handover ritual."** A special breakfast before they leave, or a small gift they open at the other parent's house, keeps you connected.

- **Plan your child-free days carefully.** These are the days to have the strongest anchors. Don't leave them empty.

## Practice: Design your ritual

**The ritual I'm starting this year:**

**When I'll do it:**

**The sensory details (music, scent, food, place):**

**Why it matters to me:**

# Chapter 6: Connection Without Pressure

When you feel lonely, the standard advice is "reach out." But reaching out can feel risky. What if they're busy? What if they say no? What if you seem needy?

This chapter is about building connection in ways that feel safe and natural, especially for women who don't want to be the "single friend who needs looking after."



## Start small and specific

A vague "We should get together sometime" rarely turns into a plan. A specific invitation almost always does better:

- "I'm making a big pot of chili on Saturday. Want to come over around 6?"
- "The Christmas market opens Friday. Want to walk around it with me after work?"
- "I'm doing a movie night on the 23rd, popcorn and terrible holiday films. Join me?"

People are often relieved to be invited. Many of them are feeling the same pressure you are.

## Host something on your terms

You do not need a partner to be a wonderful host. Some of the best holiday gatherings are the ones no one is obligated to attend:

- **A "Friendsmas"** potluck with whoever is around
- **An orphans' Christmas lunch** for friends who are far from their families
- **A cookie swap**: everyone brings a batch, everyone leaves with a mix
- **A games night** with board games and snacks
- **A New Year's Day brunch**: low key, no midnight pressure

Keep it simple. Ask people to bring something. Use paper plates if you want. The point is the company, not perfection.

## Connection beyond friends

Not every connection has to be a close friend. Light, everyday contact matters more than we think:

- Chat with the barista, the neighbor, the person walking the same dog route.
- Join a group: a choir, a winter running club, a book club, a craft class.
- Volunteer: food banks, animal shelters, hospitals and community centers often need extra help in December.
- Call or video call someone you've lost touch with. "I was thinking of you" is a beautiful message to receive.

## When you really do want to be alone

Some women spend the holidays alone by choice and love it. If that is you, wonderful. Enjoy the quiet, the freedom and the peace. You might simply want one or two small check-ins, a text or a phone call, so that solitude stays a choice and doesn't drift into isolation.

## Practice: Three invitations

Write down three people you could invite to something this month, and what you could invite them to. Then send at least one invitation today.

# Chapter 7: The Hardest Days, Hour by Hour

For many women, it all comes down to a few specific days: Christmas Eve, Christmas Day and New Year's Eve. These are the days that carry the most expectation, and when the world seems most closed.

The trick is to treat these days like you would treat any important day: with a plan.

## Christmas Eve

Christmas Eve often feels like the loneliest night of the year, because it is the evening when everyone else seems to be gathered. Give yourself a structure:

- **Afternoon:** do something active. A long walk, a swim, a yoga class, a trip to see the lights.
- **Early evening:** cook or order something you love. Make the table look beautiful, even for one.
- **Evening:** a film you've been saving, a candlelit bath, a call with a friend, a church service or concert if that speaks to you.
- **Bedtime:** something to look forward to in the morning: a gift to yourself, a special breakfast, a planned walk.

## Christmas Day

Divide the day into three parts, morning, afternoon and evening, and give each an anchor.

**Morning (my plan):**

**Afternoon (my plan):**

**Evening (my plan):**

**Who I'll talk to today:**

A few ideas that work well:

- Volunteer for a few hours at a community lunch.
- Take a long walk early in the day, when the streets are quiet and beautiful.
- Watch a film series you love, from start to finish.
- Start a big creative project: a puzzle, a painting, a recipe you've never dared to try.
- Schedule calls with friends or family at specific times, so you know when you'll hear a friendly voice.

## The days in between

The time between Christmas and New Year is strange for everyone. Routines are gone, and it's easy to drift. Choose a gentle daily structure: get up at a reasonable time, get outside, eat proper meals, and plan one thing each day, however small.

This is also a lovely time for a small reset: clearing out a cupboard, planning a trip for next year, or learning something new online.

## New Year's Eve

New Year's Eve comes with its own pressure: the midnight kiss, the big party, the feeling that you should be somewhere special. You have options:

- **Celebrate early.** Many cities have early fireworks or events. Be home by 10.
- **Celebrate somewhere else in the world.** Watch the New Year arrive in another time zone and go to bed early.
- **Make it a reflection night.** Look back on the year with the prompts in the final chapter. Write your letter to next year.
- **Go to a party, with a plan.** Arrive with a friend, set a leaving time, and remember you can go whenever you like.

There is no right way to end a year. Whatever you choose, let it be kind.

# Chapter 8: Body First

When emotions run high, the body is often the easiest place to start. You cannot always think your way out of a heavy feeling, but you can sleep, eat, move and breathe your way into a slightly better one. These are not cures. They are foundations.



## Sleep

The holidays disrupt sleep for almost everyone: late nights, rich food, alcohol, disrupted routines. Poor sleep makes everything feel harder.

- Keep your wake-up time fairly consistent, even on days off.
- Get daylight in the morning, ideally outside, ideally within an hour of waking.
- Put screens away for the last half hour before bed.

- If your mind races at night, keep a notebook by the bed and write the thoughts down. They'll still be there in the morning, and you'll handle them better.

## Food

Holidays mean treats, and treats are wonderful. But skipping meals and living on cookies and wine can leave you shaky and low. Aim for one proper meal a day with protein, vegetables and something warm. Cook something comforting in a big batch so there's always a good option ready.

## Movement

Movement is one of the most reliable mood lifters available. It doesn't have to be a workout. A 20-minute walk counts. Dancing in your kitchen counts. Stretching on the living room floor counts. Aim for something every day, especially on the hard days.

## Light

Winter's short days affect many people's mood. Spend time outside during daylight, sit near windows, and keep your home warmly lit in the evenings. If you notice a strong pattern of low mood every winter, mention it to your doctor; seasonal mood changes are common and there are good options for support.

## Alcohol

It's tempting to soften lonely evenings with a glass, or three. Alcohol can feel relaxing in the moment, but it often worsens sleep and mood

the next day. If you drink, decide your limit before you start, alternate with water, and keep a few alcohol-free nights each week. If you notice you're relying on it to get through, that's a signal worth taking seriously and talking about with someone you trust.

## Practice: My daily foundation

Tick off what you managed each day this week. Aim for progress, not perfection.

**Mon / Tue / Wed / Thu / Fri / Sat / Sun**

Daylight outside ☐☐☐☐☐☐☐

A proper meal ☐☐☐☐☐☐☐

Moved my body ☐☐☐☐☐☐☐

Talked to someone ☐☐☐☐☐☐☐

In bed on time ☐☐☐☐☐☐☐

# Chapter 9: The First Holidays After a Breakup or Divorce

The first holiday season after a relationship ends is its own kind of hard. Everything is a first: the first Christmas card signed with only your name, the first time decorating alone, the first family gathering where people tiptoe around the empty chair. Even when the ending was the right decision, even when you chose it, the firsts can catch you off guard.

## Expect the "ambush moments"

Grief after a breakup rarely arrives on schedule. It tends to ambush you in ordinary places: a song in the supermarket, the box of ornaments you bought together, the restaurant where you always had the holiday lunch, the smell of a particular cologne in a crowded shop.

You cannot avoid every ambush moment, but you can prepare for the predictable ones:

- **The decorations.** Go through them before you decorate. Keep what you love, give away or store what hurts. You are allowed to start a completely new collection.
- **Shared traditions.** List the traditions you shared. For each one, decide: keep it, change it, or pause it for this year.
- **Mutual friends and family.** Expect that some invitations will change. Some people will choose sides, some will not know what to do. Give them, and yourself, a little grace.

- **Social media.** Seriously consider muting your ex and their close circle for the season. Seeing their holiday photos will not help you heal.

## The "what I chose" list

When a relationship ends, it's easy to focus only on what you lost. Balance it with what you chose, gained or protected. Write it down, even if it feels forced at first:

**Things I chose for myself this year:**

**Things I no longer have to tolerate:**

**Things I'm discovering about myself:**

## If you share children

The first holiday season of co-parenting can be the most painful of all. A few principles help:

1. **Agree on the schedule early,** ideally in writing, so there are no last-minute surprises.
2. **Keep the handovers calm and short.** Children notice tension more than words.
3. **Don't compete on gifts.** Children remember time and warmth far more than price tags.
4. **Let them love the other parent's Christmas too.** Saying "I hope you have a wonderful time at Dad's" is a gift to them, even if it costs you something.
5. **Plan your child-free hours with special care.** These are your hardest hours. Do not leave them empty.

## When you still love them

Sometimes the hardest part isn't anger; it's missing them. You may find yourself wanting to send a "Merry Christmas" message, or wondering whether the holidays might soften things. Before you reach out, ask yourself three questions:

- What am I hoping will happen if I send this?
- How will I feel if they don't reply, or reply coldly?
- Will I feel proud of this message in a week?

If the answers make you hesitate, write the message in your journal instead. Read it again on January 2nd. You can still send it then, if you truly want to. Most women find they don't.

# Chapter 10: Holidays After a Loss

For some women, being alone during the holidays is not about relationships at all. It is about someone who died: a parent, a partner, a child, a close friend. Grief and the holidays are deeply tangled, because the season is built on memory, family and tradition.

There is no "right" way to grieve during the holidays. Some people want to keep every tradition exactly the same. Others can't bear to. Both are valid. You can also change your mind halfway through December.

## Make room for the person who is missing

Many people find comfort in actively including their loved one in the season, rather than trying not to think about them:

- Light a candle for them on a particular evening.
- Cook their signature dish, or ask someone to share their recipe.
- Hang an ornament in their memory.
- Write them a letter and read it aloud, or keep it.
- Donate to a cause they cared about.
- Tell stories about them at a gathering: "Do you remember when she…?"

You may worry that mentioning them will make others sad. Often, the opposite is true. People who loved them may be waiting for permission to say their name.

## Tell people what you need

Friends and family often don't know how to help a grieving person during the holidays. They may avoid the subject entirely or try too hard to cheer you up. It helps enormously to be specific:

- "I'd love it if you would mention Mom at dinner. It helps me to hear her name."
- "I might need to leave early. Please don't worry if I do."
- "I don't want to talk about it today, but I'd love a hug."
- "Could you call me on the 26th? That's the anniversary and I'd like to hear a friendly voice."

## Grief waves

Grief does not move in a straight line. It comes in waves, sometimes gentle, sometimes overwhelming. During a wave:

1. Find somewhere you can be alone for a few minutes, if possible.
2. Breathe slowly: in for four counts, out for six.
3. Let the tears come, if they come. They are not a sign of going backwards.
4. When the wave passes, do one small grounding thing: drink a glass of water, wash your face, step outside.

## Practice: A memory page

**A favorite holiday memory with the person I miss:**

**Something they taught me that I carry with me:**

**How I'd like to honor them this season:**

# Chapter 11: Talk to Yourself Like a Friend

Notice the way you speak to yourself during a hard evening. For many women, the inner voice is far harsher than anything they would ever say to a friend:

*"Of course you're alone. Who would want to spend Christmas with you?"*

*"Everyone else has their life together."*

*"You should be over this by now."*

If a friend said any of those things to you, you would probably stop calling them. Yet many of us live with that voice every day.

## The friend test

The next time you hear that inner critic, try this simple test. Ask: *"What would I say to my best friend if she said this about herself?"* Then say that to yourself, in the same tone you'd use with her.

> *Critic: "You're pathetic for crying over this."*

> *Friend: "Of course you're crying. You loved him, and it's Christmas. That's a lot. Let's get you a cup of tea."*

> *Critic: "Everyone else has a family to go to."*

> *Friend: "Lots of people are spending this time in different ways. You're building something new. That takes courage."*

It may feel awkward at first. That's normal. With practice, the friendlier voice gets louder.

## Three steps of self-compassion

Psychologists who study self-compassion often describe it in three parts. You can practice all three in a single minute:

1. **Notice:** "This is a hard moment." (Name it, without judgment.)
2. **Remember you're not alone:** "Many women feel this way during the holidays." (Because they do.)
3. **Offer kindness:** "May I be gentle with myself tonight." (Or put a hand on your heart, or wrap yourself in a blanket.)

## Lower the bar on purpose

The holidays come with impossible standards. You're allowed to lower them. You don't have to decorate. You don't have to send cards. You don't have to bake, host, attend every party or post a single photo. You don't have to be cheerful. You only have to take care of yourself as well as you can, one day at a time.

## Practice: A letter from your kindest friend

Write a short letter to yourself, from the point of view of the kindest friend you can imagine. What does she see in you? What would she want you to know this December?

# Chapter 12: Traveling Solo for the Holidays

For some women, the best way to spend the holidays is somewhere else entirely. A solo trip can turn a season that feels heavy into an adventure, and it removes many of the usual pressures: no family table, no couples' parties, no reminders of how things "should" be.

## Is a solo trip right for you?

A holiday trip alone can be wonderful if:

- You enjoy your own company, or want to learn to.
- You find your usual surroundings full of painful reminders.
- You'd like something to look forward to and talk about.
- Your budget allows it without causing stress in January.

It may be less helpful if you're feeling very low and isolated. In that case, a trip with a friend, or a group trip, might feel safer.

## Ideas for solo holiday travel

- **A Christmas market city:** many European cities come alive in December with lights, music and food stalls, and it's easy to feel part of the crowd.
- **A wellness retreat:** yoga, hiking, spa or meditation retreats often run special holiday programs, and many guests are traveling alone.
- **Somewhere warm:** a beach can make Christmas feel like an entirely different holiday.

- **A cozy cabin:** books, walks, a fireplace and complete quiet.
- **A group tour:** a ready-made community for the week, with no planning required.

## Staying safe and connected

- Share your itinerary with someone at home and check in daily.
- Choose well-reviewed accommodation in central, well-lit areas.
- Plan the big days (Christmas Eve, Christmas Day) in advance: a special dinner reservation, a concert, a tour.
- Bring a journal. Solo travel is a wonderful time for reflection.

## Practice: Dream it first

Even if you can't travel this year, dreaming is free, and it can be a lovely project for a quiet evening.

**If I could spend the holidays anywhere, I'd go to:**

**What I'd do on Christmas Day there:**

**What it would give me that home doesn't:**

**One small step toward making it happen (this year or next):**

# Chapter 13: Dating During the Holidays (If You Want To)

Let's be clear: you do not need to date to have a good holiday season. Being single is not a problem to be solved before December 25th. But if you *want* to meet someone, the holidays can be a surprisingly good time for it, as long as you go in with clear eyes.

## Watch out for "cuffing season" pressure

Many people feel a stronger urge to pair up when the weather turns cold and the holidays approach. That's natural. It can also lead to rushing into something just to avoid being alone at Christmas. Ask yourself honestly: *"Would I be interested in this person in June?"*

## Low-pressure ways to meet people

- Holiday events: markets, concerts, charity runs, community events
- Volunteering, which is also a wonderful way to see someone's character
- Friends' parties: tell a couple of trusted friends you're open to meeting someone
- Classes and clubs that continue into the new year
- Dating apps, with clear boundaries about time and energy

## Keep your peace

If you date during the season, a few gentle boundaries help:

- Don't introduce someone new to your family at the holidays unless you truly want to.
- Keep your own plans and traditions. Don't drop them for someone you met three weeks ago.
- Notice how you feel after a date: calmer, or more anxious? That tells you a lot.
- Remember that a disappointing date is just information, not a verdict on your worth.

## If you don't want to date

That's a complete answer. Some seasons are for healing, for friendship, for getting to know yourself again. "I'm not dating right now" is a full sentence, to others and to yourself.

# Chapter 14: Stories From the Season

The women in this chapter are composites, drawn from common experiences rather than real individuals. You may recognize a little of yourself in one of them.

## Anna, 41: "I thought I'd hate it."

Anna's divorce was finalized in October. Her ex had the children for Christmas Eve and Christmas morning that first year, and she dreaded it for weeks. Instead of leaving the time empty, she made a plan: a 10 a.m. swim, a late breakfast with a friend who was also on her own, an afternoon wrapping presents for the children's "second Christmas" on the 26th, and an early night with a new novel. "It wasn't magical," she says, "but it was mine. And when the kids came home, we had pancakes and opened presents in our pajamas, and it felt just as special."

*What helped:* anchors for every part of the day, and moving the family celebration instead of mourning the date.

## Maria, 34: "The question."

Every year, Maria's aunt asked about her love life, loudly, at the table. This year Maria decided her answer in advance and practiced it in the car: *"Not right now, and I'm really happy. Now, tell me how you made this incredible pie."* Her aunt laughed and launched into the recipe. "I couldn't believe it was that easy," Maria says. "I'd spent years dreading it."

*What helped:* deciding on a script and redirecting with a genuine question.

## Helen, 58: "The first year without him."

Helen's husband died in the spring. She couldn't face the big family Christmas, so she asked her daughter to host a small lunch instead, and they each brought one of his favorite dishes. At dessert they told stories about him, and for the first time in months she laughed. "I thought remembering him would make it harder," she says. "It made it lighter."

*What helped:* including the person who was missing, and telling family what she needed.

## Jess, 29: "Too much scrolling."

Jess realized she spent every evening in December scrolling engagement announcements and feeling worse. She muted a dozen accounts, put her phone in the kitchen at 9 p.m., and joined a winter running club. "I'm not saying I didn't feel lonely sometimes," she says, "but I felt like I was living my own life again instead of watching everyone else's."

*What helped:* a simple digital plan and replacing scrolling with something social.

## Practice: Your story

Imagine it's next January and a friend asks how your holidays went. What would you love to be able to say? Write it here, in the past tense, as if it already happened.

# Chapter 15: A 7-Day Reset for January

January can feel like a hangover from the holidays: grey days, tight budgets, and a sudden drop in social plans. For women who found December hard, the first week of January is a perfect time for a gentle reset.

**Day 1: Rest.** Sleep in if you can. Spend the day doing as little as possible, on purpose.

**Day 2: Clear.** Take down the decorations. Open the windows. Clean one room thoroughly.

**Day 3: Move.** Choose a type of movement you might enjoy this year and try it once: a class, a long walk, a swim, a dance video at home.

**Day 4: Plan something to look forward to.** A weekend away in spring, a concert, a course, a visit with a friend. Put it in the calendar.

**Day 5: Connect.** Arrange one get-together for January. Winter is long; don't wait for someone else to organize it.

**Day 6: Money check.** Look at what you spent in December, without judgment. Make a simple plan to recover, if needed.

**Day 7: Choose your theme.** Pick one word for the year ahead: *steady, brave, home, joy, growth, ease*. Write it where you'll see it every day.

**My word for the year:**

**Three things I'm looking forward to:**

**One way I'll keep myself connected this winter:**

# Chapter 16: Money and Gifts on Your Terms

Holiday spending carries an emotional weight that's easy to overlook. For single women, it often comes with extra layers: managing on one income, buying for nieces, nephews, friends and colleagues, feeling obliged to match what couples spend, or overspending to fill an emotional gap.

## Decide your number first

Before you buy anything, decide on a total holiday budget, one you can pay off by the end of January at the latest. Then divide it:

**My total holiday budget:**

_____

**Gifts: _____ Food & hosting: _____ Outings & travel: _____**

**Something just for me: _____ Charity/giving: _____**

Notice that last-but-one line. Many women spend the whole season giving and nothing on themselves. A small, planned gift to yourself, a book, a candle, a massage, a nice bottle of something, is not selfish. It's a way of telling yourself that you count too.

## Gifts that cost less and mean more

- **Time gifts:** an afternoon of babysitting, a homemade dinner, a day trip together.
- **Homemade:** cookies in a pretty jar, a playlist, a printed photo, a handwritten letter.
- **Group gifts:** suggest a Secret Santa among friends or family to reduce the number of presents.
- **Experiences:** cinema vouchers, a class, a museum pass.

## It's okay to say no

If a gift exchange, a pricey night out, or an expensive trip doesn't fit your budget, you can say so kindly and clearly:

- "I'm keeping things simple this year. I'd love to just get together for coffee."
- "I'm sitting this one out, but I'll join you for the walk on Sunday."

Real friends will understand. And the relief of not starting January in debt is a gift in itself.

## Avoid the late-night "retail therapy" trap

Online shopping at midnight, after a hard evening, is one of the easiest ways to overspend. If you notice the pattern: delete saved card details, unsubscribe from sale emails, and put items in your basket but wait 24 hours before buying. Most of the urge passes.

# Chapter 17: When It's More Than the Holiday Blues

Most of what this book describes is the ordinary heaviness of a demanding season. It hurts, but it passes. Sometimes, though, what we feel is bigger, deeper, or longer-lasting than the holiday blues. It's important to know the difference, and to know that help is available.

## Signs it's time to talk to someone

Consider reaching out to your doctor or a mental health professional if, for two weeks or more, you notice:

- Feeling low, empty or hopeless most of the day, most days
- Losing interest in things you usually enjoy
- Big changes in sleep or appetite
- Difficulty concentrating or making simple decisions
- Feeling worthless, or excessively guilty
- Withdrawing from everyone
- Relying on alcohol or other substances to cope

These can be signs of depression, which is common, real and treatable. Getting help is a sign of strength, not weakness.

## If you are in crisis

If you have thoughts of harming yourself or ending your life, please reach out right now:

- **United States:** call or text **988** (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline)

- **United Kingdom & Ireland:** call **Samaritans at 116 123**
- **Elsewhere:** call your local emergency number, or search for your country's crisis line
- If you are in immediate danger, call emergency services

You do not have to explain everything perfectly. You only need to say: *"I'm having a really hard time and I need to talk to someone."*

## Make a support list now

Write down a few people and places you can contact on a hard day. Do it now, while you feel steady, so it's ready when you need it.

**A friend I can call anytime:**

**A family member who gets it:**

**My doctor / therapist:**

**Crisis line in my country:**

**Something that helps me in the first ten minutes of a bad moment:**

# Chapter 18: Your New Year




As the season ends, something lovely often happens: the noise fades, the decorations come down, and life feels like yours again. This is the perfect moment to look back on what this December taught you, and to look forward with a little more kindness.

## Looking back

Answer these questions honestly. There are no wrong answers.

**What was harder than I expected this season?**

**What was easier, or better, than I expected?**

**Which moment would I happily live again?**

**What did I learn about what I need?**

## Looking forward

Instead of resolutions, which often feel like a list of ways we're not good enough, try *intentions*: gentle directions for the year ahead.

**One thing I want more of in my life next year:**

**One thing I'm ready to let go of:**

**One new thing I'd like to try:**

**One way I'll take care of myself every week:**

## A letter to next December's you

Write a letter to the woman who will open this book next December. Tell her what you've learned. Tell her what you hope for her. Tell her she'll be okay, because she will.

## A final word

Being on your own for the holidays is not a sign that something is missing from you. It's simply a chapter of a life, one that can hold peace, freedom, friendship, creativity, rest and joy, alongside the harder feelings.

You made it through another season. That matters. Be proud of yourself.

With warmth,

*Clara*

# Bonus: 24 Days of Gentle Kindness

A small daily practice for December 1–24. Tick each one off as you go, or do them in any order you like.

1. Make your bed with fresh sheets and light a candle tonight.
2. Text one person: "I was thinking of you today."
3. Take a 20-minute walk without your phone.
4. Write down three things your body did for you today.
5. Mute three accounts that make you feel worse.
6. Cook a favorite childhood meal.
7. Watch the sunset, or the city lights, for five minutes.
8. Clear one small space at home: a drawer, a shelf, a bag.
9. Make a playlist of songs that make you feel strong.
10. Give a genuine compliment to a stranger.
11. Write one paragraph about something you're proud of from this year.
12. Take yourself out for a hot chocolate.
13. Donate something you no longer need.
14. Go to bed an hour early.
15. Call someone older than you and ask about their favorite holiday memory.
16. Buy or make yourself one small gift.
17. Try a new recipe.
18. Spend 10 minutes stretching.

19. Write a thank-you note to someone who helped you this year.
20. Look through old photos and pick your three favorites from the year.
21. On the shortest day of the year, write what you're letting go of.
22. Plan your Christmas Day anchors.
23. Have a cozy movie night with your favorite snack.
24. Do one thing purely for joy.

# Journal Pages

Use these pages however you like: for morning pages, for venting, for gratitude, for plans.

**Date: _____**

**Date: _____**

**Date: _____**

**Date: _____**

**Date: _____**

**Date: _____**

# Bonus: The Scripts Library

Sometimes the hardest part is finding the words. Borrow these exactly as they are, or change them to sound like you.

## Reaching out when you feel lonely

- "Hey, I'm having a quiet evening and thought of you. Free for a call this week?"
- "I'm on my own on the 25th this year. Any chance you'd like to go for a walk that morning?"
- "This season is harder than I expected. I don't need advice, I'd just love to hear your voice."

## Inviting people over

- "I'm doing a low-key 'leftovers and movies' night on the 27th. Pajamas encouraged. Come?"
- "Cookie swap at mine on Saturday. Bring one batch, leave with six kinds."
- "New Year's Day brunch, 11 a.m., no hangover judgment. You in?"

## Declining kindly

- "Thank you so much for thinking of me. I'm keeping this year quiet, but let's get together in January."
- "I can't make the whole evening, but I'd love to stop by for an hour."

- "I'm sitting out the gift exchange this year. I'll bring the dessert instead!"

## Asking for support

- "Could you check in with me on Christmas Eve? Just a quick text would mean a lot."
- "I'd love it if we could talk about Dad at dinner. I don't want to pretend he isn't missing."
- "I might need to step out for a bit during the party. If I do, I'm fine, I just need air."

## Handling comments about being single

- "I'm really happy with my life right now. How's work going for you?"
- "When there's news, you'll be the first to know!" (Then change the subject.)
- "I'd rather not talk about dating today."

## With an ex, about the children

- "Can we confirm the holiday schedule by the 1st, in writing, so the kids know what to expect?"
- "I'll have them ready at 10 on the 24th. Please text if anything changes."
- "I hope you all have a lovely time. They're excited to see you."

# Bonus: 30 Cozy Ideas for a Solo Evening

1. Make a "fancy plate" dinner: candles, cloth napkin, the good glass.
2. Bake one small batch of cookies from a recipe you've never tried.
3. Start a 500-piece puzzle with a holiday playlist.
4. Watch a classic film you've never seen.
5. Write three postcards to friends, by hand.
6. Take a long bath with salts, a book and a do-not-disturb sign.
7. Walk around your neighborhood to look at the lights.
8. Try a beginner online class: drawing, calligraphy, a language.
9. Rearrange one corner of your home to make it cozier.
10. Make a vision board for next year.
11. Bake bread, or simply make a big pot of soup for the week.
12. Listen to a whole album, lying down, eyes closed.
13. Learn a new card game or solitaire variation.
14. Make a hot chocolate bar for one, with every topping.
15. Paint your nails in a festive color.
16. Read old letters, cards or journals.
17. Make a playlist of songs from every year of your life.
18. Do a guided relaxation or yoga video.
19. Write a short story or poem, just for you.
20. Plan a summer adventure.
21. Make gift tags or wrapping paper by hand.

22. Call someone in a different time zone.
23. Visit a late-night museum or gallery event.
24. Learn the words to a carol in another language.
25. Make a "comfort box" for hard days: tea, a candle, a favorite note, a good book.
26. Go to a cinema alone; choose the best seat.
27. Watch the stars, or the snow, wrapped in a blanket.
28. Clear your photo library and print your ten favorites.
29. Write down 25 things you love about your life right now.
30. Go to bed early with fresh sheets and nowhere to be in the morning.

# More Journal Pages

**Date: _____**

**Date: _____**

**Date: _____**

**Date: _____**

**Date: _____**

**Date: _____**

# Where to Go From Here

You made it through this book, and that is more than most people ever do. If you'd like to take the next step:

- *The Woman Who Started Over* (coming soon): rebuilding your life and your children's sense of home after divorce

## More Gentle Life Guides

- *Give Them Back Their Wonder*: 100 screen-free games and a calm plan for the school break
- *I Didn't Mean to Yell* (coming soon): for moms who love fiercely and lose their temper anyway
- *Who Takes Care of Mom?* (coming soon): a 30-day reset for women carrying the invisible load
- *Brave Little Hearts* (coming soon): helping your anxious child grow courage, one small step at a time

You can find every guide on Amazon by searching for "Clara Whitfield".

## A Small Favor

If even one page of this book helped you, would you consider leaving an honest review on Amazon? It takes a minute, and it helps someone else find a book that might help them too.